

Passages - The Sailor Who Fell from Grace with the Sea

Those men have thrown opportunity away - there's no hope for them any more. I've never done much, but I've lived my whole life thinking of myself as the only real man. And if I'm right, then a limpid, lonely horn is going to trumpet through the dawn someday, and a turgid cloud laced with light will sweep down, and the poignant voice of glory will call for me from the distance - and I'll have to jump out of bed and set out alone.

The skinned neck, draped gracefully on the floor, seemed to be wearing a cat mask. The cat was only an exterior, life had posed as a cat.

The less time they had, the better. The shorter this meeting was, the less perfection would be marred.

Poising motionless on the water, the ship sounded three blasts on her horn. Uneasy silence followed, an interval of quiescence during which it seemed that Ryuji aboard ship and Fusako and Noboru on the pier were trapped in the same viscous moment of time.

Are you getting cold? ...Are you getting cold? Ryuji asked again and again, and all the time he was directing another question to himself: Are you really going to give it up? The feeling of the sea, the dark, drunken feeling that unearthly rolling always brings? The thrill of saying goodbye? The sweet tears you weep for your song? Are you going to give up the life which has detached you from the world, kept you remote, impelled you

toward the pinnacle of manliness? The secret yearning for death. The glory beyond and the death beyond. Everything was

"beyond, wrong or right, had always been 'beyond? Are you going to give that up?

80 - And yet Ryuji had discovered on the return leg of his last voyage that he was tired, tired to death of the squalor and the boredom is a sailor's life. He was convinced that he had tasted it all, even the lees, and he was gluttoned. What a fool he'd been! There was no glory to be found, not anywhere in the world. Not in the Northern Hemisphere. Not in the Southern Hemisphere. Not even beneath that star every sailor dreams about, the Southern Cross!

101 - His purity was as brittle as a new moon.

His innocence had sent an intricate net of feelers snaking toward the world, but when would they be snapped? When would the world lose its vastness and lace him in a strait jacket?

104 -Noboru had never received such cordial treatment from the adults, nor had he ever seen them so ridiculously hesitant in his presence. It seemed to be some special adult ritual. He knew what they were going to say and it interested him very little. But he did enjoy watching them handle him from across the table as though he were a vulnerable, easily frightened, and all-unknowing little bird - that was a real spectacle.

108 -'I thought I wouldn't feel embarrassed if all the lights were out, but it was just the opposite.

The darkness becomes a huge eye and

you feel as if you're being watched the whole time.'

117 - When a gear slips out of place it's our job to force it back into position. If we don't, order will turn to chaos. We all know that the world is empty and that the important thing, the only thing, is to try to maintain order in that emptiness. And so we are guards, and more than that because we also have executive power to insure that order is maintained.

120 - This law is the adults' way of expressing the high hopes they have for us. But it also represents all the dreams they've never been able to make come true. They've assumed just because they've roped themselves so tight they can't even budge that we must be helpless too; they've been careless enough to allow us here, and only here, a glimpse of blue sky and absolute freedom.

131 - Ryuji mused on without even turning his head. He recalled the shapes of islands he had visited. Makatea in the South Pacific and New Caledonia. The West Indies: seething with languor and melancholy, teeming with condor and parrots and, everywhere you looked, palms. Emperor palms. Wine palms. Surging out of the splendor of the sea, death had swept down on him like a stormy bank of clouds. A vision of death now eternally beyond his reach, majestic, acclaimed, heroic death unfurled its rapture across his brain. And if the world had been provided for just this radiant death, then why shouldn't the world also perish for it!

Waves, as tepid as blood, inside an atoll. The tropical sun blaring across the sky like the call of a brass trumpet. The many-

colored sea.

Sharks...

131 - Still immersed in his dream, he drank down the tepid tea. It tasted bitter. Glory, as anyone knows, is bitter stuff.